



Dionysus, Pan, Echo, and Narcissus

Reenactment of the Marriage of Dionysus and Ariadne When Dionysus cast his eyes upon her, he danced over to her and like a lover sat upon her lap. He took her in his arms and kissed her. Ariadne behaved modestly, but nevertheless she lovingly embraced him. When the party-guests beheld this, they kept applauding and shouting for an encore. And when Dionysus got up and drew Ariadne up with him, then you could see a real performance, as they proceeded to kiss and fondle one another. The audience saw a very good-looking Dionysus and a gorgeous Ariadne not playing a role but truly kissing each other and they all watched with great excitement. . . . In the end the dinner guests seeing the couple embracing and moving off to their marriage-bed, the unmarried ones vowed to get married, those who were already married got on their horses and rode off to visit their wives.

—XENOPHON, *Symposium* 9.4–7

The Birth, Childhood, and Origins of Dionysus

The traditional account of the birth of Dionysus (Bacchus)¹ runs as follows. Disguised as a mortal, Zeus was having an affair with **Semele**, a daughter of **Cadmus**. When Hera found out, her jealousy led her to get even. She appeared to Semele disguised as an old woman and convinced her rival that she should ask her lover to appear in the full magnificence of his divinity. Semele first persuaded Zeus to swear that he would grant whatever she might ask of him, and then she revealed her demand. Zeus was unwilling but was obliged to comply, and Semele was burned to a cinder by the splendor of his person and the fire of his lightning flash. The unborn child, being divine, was not destroyed in the conflagration; Zeus saved his son from the ashes of his mother and sewed him up in his own thigh, from which he was born again at the proper time.²

Various nurses are associated with the infant Dionysus, in particular certain nymphs of Nysa, a mountain of legendary fame located in various parts of the ancient world. Hermes, who had rescued Dionysus from Semele's ashes, carried the baby to the nymphs of Nysa. **Ino**, Semele's sister, is traditionally singled out as one who

cared for the god when he was a baby.³ When Dionysus reached manhood, he carried the message of his worship far and wide, bringing happiness and prosperity to those who would listen and madness and death to those who dared oppose. The tradition of his arrival in Greece stresses the belief that he is a latecomer to the Olympian pantheon and that his origins lie in Thrace and ultimately Phrygia.⁴ Since the name Dionysus (clearly that of the god) appears in the linear B tablets, his worship must have been introduced into Greece in the Bronze Age, earlier than previously conjectured by scholars, probably in the Mycenaean period and perhaps in the time of the legendary Cadmus, as Euripides assumes.

The *Bacchae* of Euripides

Dionysus is basically a god of vegetation in general, and in particular of the vine, the grape, and the making and drinking of wine. But his person and his teaching eventually embrace very much more. The best source for the profound meaning of his worship and its most universal implications is found in Euripides' *Bacchae* (*The Bacchic Women*). Whatever one makes of the playwright's depiction of the rites in a literal sense, the sublimity and terror of the spiritual message are inescapable and timeless. The *Bacchae* is essential for understanding the complex nature of Dionysus and his worship.



The Death of Semele, by Peter Paul Rubens (1577–1640); oil on panel, 1636, 10 ½ × 15 ½ in. Both Semele and Zeus are shown under extreme emotion—she, as death approaches, and he, rising from her couch with pity and horror, knowing her coming agony. He holds the thunderbolt back in his right hand, and his eagle grips it in its beak. (*Musées royaux des Beaux-Arts de Belgique, Bruxelles*; *Koninklijke Musea voor Schone Kunsten van België, Brussel*)

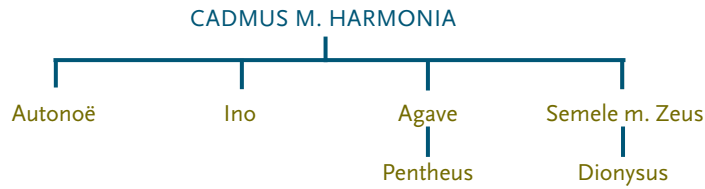


Figure 13.1. The Children of Cadmus. (A fuller genealogy for the House of Cadmus is given on p. 415.)

The play opens with Dionysus himself, who has come in anger to Thebes; his mother's integrity has been questioned by her own relatives, and the magnitude and power of his very godhead have been challenged and repudiated; the sisters of Semele claim (and **Pentheus**, grandson of Cadmus and now king of Thebes, agrees) that she became pregnant because she slept with a mortal and that Cadmus was responsible for the story that Zeus was the father of her child; as a result, Zeus killed her with a blast of lightning (1–63):



The Indian Triumph of Dionysus. Roman marble sarcophagus, mid-second century A.D.; width (without lid) 92 in., height 39 in., lid, width 93 in., height 12 ½ in. Dionysus rides on a chariot drawn by panthers. He is preceded by satyrs, maenads, silenoi, and animals, among which elephants and lions are prominent. He has come from India, bringing happiness and fertility to the Greek world. On the lid are reliefs of the death of Semele, the birth of Dionysus from the thigh of Zeus, and his nurture by the nymphs of Nysa. Hermes appears in each of the three scenes on the lid—rescuing the infant from the dying Semele in the left panel; taking him to the nymphs in the center panel after his birth from the thigh of Zeus, and pointing toward the scene of his nurture by the nymphs in the right panel. The sarcophagus is one of seven found in the tomb of the family of the Calpurnii Pisones in Rome. (*Sarcophagus with the Triumph of Dionysus*, Anonymous, Roman, ca. 190, Thasian marble, 47 ½ × 92 ½ × 40 × 35 13/16 in [120.7 × 234.9 × 101.6 × 90.96 cm]; Photo © The Walters Museum, Baltimore)



Closer Look



Audio

DIONYSUS: I, Dionysus, the son of Zeus, have come to this land of the Thebans; my mother Semele, the daughter of Cadmus, gave birth to me, delivered by a fiery blast of lightning. I am here by the stream of Dirce and the waters of the Ismenus, not as a god but in disguise as a man. I see here near the palace the shrine that commemorates my mother, who was struck dead by the lightning blast, and the ruins of her home, smoldering yet from the flame of Zeus' fire that still lives—the everlasting evidence of Hera's outrage against my mother. I am pleased with Cadmus for setting this area off as a holy sanctuary dedicated to his daughter, and I have enclosed it round about with the fresh greenery of the clustering vine. (1–12)

I left the fertile plains of gold in Lydia and Phrygia and made my way across the sunny plateaus of Persia, the walled towns of Bactria, the grim land of the Medes, rich Arabia, and the entire coast of Asia Minor, where Hellenes and non-Hellenes live together in teeming cities with beautiful towers. After having led my Bacchic dance and established my mysteries in these places, I have come to this city of the Hellenes first. (13–22)

I have raised the Bacchic cry and clothed my followers in the fawn-skin and put into their hands the thyrsus—my ivy-covered shaft—here in Thebes first of all Greece, because my mother's sisters claim (as least of all they should) that I, Dionysus, was not begotten of Zeus but that Semele became pregnant by some mortal man and through the clever instigations of Cadmus laid the blame on Zeus; they gloatingly proclaim that Zeus because of her deception struck her dead. (23–31)

And so these same sisters I have stung with madness, driving them from their homes, and they inhabit Mt. Cithaeron, bereft of sense; I have compelled them to take up the symbols of my rituals, and all the women of Thebes—the entire female population—I have driven from their homes in frenzy. Together with the daughters of Cadmus they sit out in the open air on rocks under the evergreens. For although it does not wish to, this city must learn full well that it is still not completely schooled in my Bacchic mysteries and I must defend the reputation of my mother Semele by showing myself to mortals as the god whom she bore to Zeus. (32–42)

Cadmus has handed over the prerogatives of his royal power to his daughter's son, Pentheus, who fights against my godhead, thrusting me aside in sacrifices and never mentioning my name in prayers. Therefore I shall show myself as a god to him and all the Thebans. And when I have settled matters here, I shall move on to another place and reveal myself. If the city of Thebes in anger tries by force to drive the Bacchae down from the mountains, I shall



The Birth of Dionysus. Attic red-figure lekythos, by the Alkimachos painter, ca. 460 B.C. The birth of Dionysus is not a very common subject on ancient vases. The artist of this vase has rendered the scene with sensitivity. It conveys the moment of the birth of this powerful god with stillness and a strangely detached curiosity on the part of Zeus and Hermes. Zeus, with a wreath on his head, long locks, and beard, sits naked upon a rock, covered with the garments he has just removed. Hermes, garbed in his traveling hat and winged sandals, stands waiting, intent upon the birth, dutifully holding his father's scepter in one hand and his caduceus in the other. Hermes will take the child to the nymphs of Nysa to be raised. Zeus attends to his own delivery, as his newborn son just begins to push his head out of his father's thigh. (Photograph © 2010. Museum of Fine Arts, Boston)



The Second Birth of Dionysus, by George Platt Lynes (1907–1955), 3 11/16 × 3 in. Photographer George Platt Lynes worked within a surrealist-inspired aesthetic and was particularly influential in the development of the homoerotic representation of the male nude. In his early travels abroad, particularly in France of the expatriate era (1920s and 1930s), he developed close friendships with a number of influential artists, such as Gertrude Stein, Jean Cocteau, and Monroe Wheeler (affiliated with the Museum of Modern Art in New York). In the early 1930s, he worked as a photographer for such magazines as *Harper's Bazaar* and *Vogue*. The fame of his fashion photography soon led to work as a documentary photographer for dance companies, especially George Balanchine's American Ballet Company (now the New York City Ballet), which included the ballet *Orpheus*. From 1937 to 1940, Lynes began a series of works based on Greek myth, including Endymion, Narcissus, Danaë, and the birth of Dionysus shown here. In his last years, he began an association with noted sex researcher Alfred Kinsey. Lynes himself was afraid of the reception his homoerotic images, which included some of his most creative output, would receive and had many of these destroyed. He died in poverty and almost forgotten. Subsequent exhibitions of his work since his death have reestablished him as a major photographer of the twentieth century. In the work shown here he displays a characteristic virtuosity in his use of light and shadow, together with an uncanny and unsettling focus on the pose of the figures. The naked figure of Zeus, here erotically charged, in contrast to his representation in the vase depicting the birth of Dionysus, is frozen in the moment of the agonizing pain, not to say horror, of the birth, which itself is represented in a disconcertingly and clinically realistic fashion. (© Estate of George Platt Lynes, Photo © The Metropolitan Museum of Art/Art Resource, NY)

join them in their madness as their war commander. This then is why I have assumed a mortal form and changed myself into the likeness of a man. (43–54) 40

O you women whom I have taken as companions of my journey from foreign lands, leaving the Lydian mountain Tmolus far behind, come raise the tambourines, invented by the great mother Rhea, and by me, and native to the land of Phrygia. Come and surround the royal palace of Pentheus and beat out your din so that the city of Cadmus may see. I will go to my Bacchae on the slopes of Cithaeron, where they are, and join with them in their dances. (55–63)

The chorus of women that follows reveals the exultant spirit and mystic aura surrounding the celebration of their god's mysteries (64–167):

CHORUS: Leaving Asia and holy Mt. Tmolus, we run in sweet pain and lovely weariness with ecstatic Bacchic cries in the wake of the roaring god Dionysus. Let everyone, indoors or out, keep their respectful distance and hold their tongue in sacred silence as we sing the appointed hymn to Bacchus. (64–72)



Audio



Dionysus and Maenads.

Attic red-figure amphora, by the Kleophrades painter, ca. 490 B.C.; height 56 cm. Dionysus, bearded and with long hair in ringlets down his neck, is moving to the right, though his head is turned to the left, perhaps to indicate an inebriated state. He holds a kantharos (wine cup) in his right hand and a vine branch in his left. He is wearing a dappled animal skin around his shoulders and a garland of ivy on his head. On either side of Dionysus, maenads are being assailed by satyrs. Each of the maenads is mimicking the posture of Dionysus, moving in one direction toward the god while facing the other. Both maenads carry the thyrsus, and the maenad on the left is also holding a serpent. On the neck, three athletes are seen with discus and spear. (*Staatliche Antikensammlungen und Glyptothek München*. Photograph by Renate Kühling)

Happy is the one who, blessed with the knowledge of the divine mysteries, leads a life of ritual purity and joins the holy group of revelers, heart and soul, as they honor their god Bacchus in the mountains with holy ceremonies of purification. He participates in mysteries ordained by the great mother, Cybele herself, as he follows his god, Dionysus, brandishing a thyrsus. (73–82)

Run, run, Bacchae, bringing the roaring god, Dionysus, son of a god, out of the Phrygian mountains to the spacious streets of Hellas. (83–87) 10

Once when his mother carried him in her womb, the lightning bolt flew from the hand of Zeus and she brought the child forth prematurely with the pains of a labor forced on her too soon, and she gave up her life in the fiery blast. Immediately Zeus, the son of Cronus, took up the child and enclosed him in the secret recess of his thigh with fastenings of gold, and hid him from Hera thus in a second womb. When the Fates had so decreed, Zeus bore the bull-horned god and wreathed his head with a crown of serpents, and so the Maenads hunt and catch wild snakes and twine them in their hair. (88–104)

O Thebes, crown yourself with ivy, burst forth luxuriant in verdant leaves and lovely berries; join the Bacchic frenzy with branches torn from trees of oak or fir and consecrate your cloak of dappled fawnskin with white tufts of purest wool. Be reverent with the violent powers of the thyrsus. Straightway the whole land will dance its way (whoever leads the sacred group represents the roaring god himself) to the mountain, to the mountain where the crowd of women waits, driven from their labors at the loom by the maddening sting of Dionysus. (105–119) 20

O secret chamber on Crete, holy cavern where Zeus was born, attended by the Curetes!⁵ Here the Corybantes with their three-crested helmets invented for us this drum of hide stretched tight and their ecstatic revels mingled its tense beat with the sweet alluring breath of the Phrygian flutes, and they put it into the hand of mother Rhea, so that she might beat an accompaniment to the cries of her Bacchic women. The satyrs in their frenzy took up the drum from the mother-goddess and added it to the music of their dances during the festivities in which Dionysus delights. (120–134) 30

How sweet it is in the mountains when, out of the rushing throng, the priest of the roaring god falls to the ground in his quest for blood and with a joyful cry devours the raw flesh of the slaughtered goat. The plain flows with milk and wine and the nectar of bees; but the Bacchic celebrant runs on, brandishing his pine torch, and the flame streams behind with smoke as sweet as Syrian frankincense. He urges on the wandering band with shouts and renews their frenzied dancing, as his delicate locks toss in the breeze. (135–150) 40

Amid the frantic shouts is heard his thunderous cry: "Run, run, Bacchae, you the pride of Tmolus with its streams of gold. Celebrate the god Dionysus on your thundering drums, honoring this deity of joy with Phrygian cries and shouts of ecstasy, while the melodious and holy flute sounds its sacred accompaniment as you throng, to the mountain, to the mountain." (151–165)

Every Bacchanal runs and leaps in joy, just like a foal that frisks beside her mother in the pasture.

The scene that follows (170–313) is fraught with tragic humor and bitter irony. Cadmus (retired king) and Tiresias (priest of the traditional religion) welcome the new god with motives that are startling in their blatant pragmatism. Each of them sees personal advantage in accepting the rites of the new god. In their joyous rejuvenation, these two old men, experienced realists, present just the

right foil for the introduction of the doomed Pentheus, who, in his mortal blindness, dares to challenge the god, his cousin, Dionysus.

TIRESIAS: Who attends at the gate? Summon Cadmus from the house, the son of Agenor, who came from Sidonia and fortified the city of the Thebans. Let someone go and announce that Tiresias wants to see him. He already knows for what reason I have come. I made an agreement with him, even though I am old and he is even older, to make myself a thyrsus, wear a fawnskin, and crown my head with shoots of ivy. (170–177)

CADMUS: My dearest friend, I knew your voice from inside the palace, and recognized the wise words of a wise man. I have come ready with the paraphernalia of the god. For since Dionysus, who has revealed himself to mortals as a god, is the son of my daughter, I must do everything in my power to magnify his greatness. Where should we go to join the others in the dance, shaking our gray heads in ecstasy? Tell me, an old man, Tiresias, for you are old too and wise. I shall never grow tired by night or by day as I strike the ground with my thyrsus. It will be a sweet pleasure to forget that we are old. (178–188) 10

TIRESIAS: You experience the same sensations as I do, for I feel young again and I shall attempt the dance.

CADMUS: Shall we not proceed to the mountain by chariot?

TIRESIAS: No, the god would not have as appropriate an honor.

CADMUS: I will lead the way for you, two old men together.

TIRESIAS: The god will lead the two of us there without any difficulty. 20

CADMUS: Are we to be the only men of the city to dance in honor of Bacchus? (195)

TIRESIAS: We are the only ones who think the way one should; the others are wrong and perverse.

CADMUS: We delay too long; give me your hand.

TIRESIAS: Here it is, take hold and join our hands together.

CADMUS: Being a mere mortal, I am not scornful of the gods.

TIRESIAS: About the gods we have no new wise speculations. The ancestral beliefs that we hold are as old as time, and they cannot be destroyed by any argument or clever subtlety invented by profound minds. How could I help being ashamed, one will ask, as I am about to join in the dance, at my age, with an ivy wreath on my head? The god does not discriminate whether young or old must dance in his honor, but he desires to be esteemed by all alike and wishes his glory to be magnified, making no distinctions whatsoever. (200–209) 20

CADMUS: Since you are blind, Tiresias, I shall be a prophet for you, and tell you what I see. Pentheus, the son of Echion, to whom I have given my royal power in Thebes, comes in haste to this palace. How excited he is; what news has he to tell us? (210–214)

PENTHEUS: Although I happened to have been away from Thebes, I have heard of the new evils that beset the city; the women have abandoned our homes on the pretense of Bacchic rites and gad about on the dark mountainside honoring by their dances the new god, Dionysus, whoever he is. Bowls full of wine stand in the midst of each group, and they sneak away one by one to solitary places where they satisfy the lust of males. Their pretext is that they are Maenad priestesses, but they put Aphrodite ahead of Bacchus. All those I have caught are kept safe with their hands tied by guards in the state prison. The others, who still roam on the mountain, I shall hunt out, including my own mother, Agave, and 40

her sisters, Ino and Autonoë, the mother of Actaeon. And when I have bound them fast in iron chains, I shall soon put an end to this evil Bacchism. (215–232)

They say too that a stranger has come here from Lydia, some wizard and sorcerer, with scented hair and golden curls, who has the wine-dark charms of Aphrodite in his eyes. He spends both night and day in the company of young girls, enticing them with his Bacchic mysteries. If I catch him here in my palace, I'll cut off his head and put a stop to his thyrsus-pounding and head-tossing. That fellow is the one who claims that Dionysus is a god, who was once sewn up in the thigh of Zeus, when he was in fact destroyed by the fiery blast of lightning along with his mother, because she lied and said that Zeus had been her husband. Whoever this stranger may be, does he not deserve to hang for such hubris? (233–247) 50

But here is another miracle—I see the prophet Tiresias in a dappled fawn-skin, and my mother's father, a very funny sight, playing the Bacchant with a wand of fennel reed. I refuse, sir, to stand by and see you behave so senselessly in your old age. You are my grandfather; won't you toss away your garland of ivy and rid your hand of the thyrsus? (248–254) 60

You persuaded him, Tiresias. Why? By introducing this new divinity among people do you hope that he will afford you an additional source of income from your omens and your sacrifices? If it were not for your gray hairs, you would not escape being bound and imprisoned along with the Bacchae for initiating evil rites. As far as women are concerned, I maintain that whenever the gleam of wine is in their feasts, there can be nothing further that is wholesome in their ceremonies. (255–262) 70

CHORUS: What sacrilege, sir! Do you not have respect for the gods and Cadmus, who sowed the seeds from which the earthborn men arose; are you, the son of Echion, who was one of them, bringing shame on your own family? (262–265)

TIRESIAS: Whenever a wise man takes a good theme for his argument, it is no great task to speak well. You seem to be a man of intelligence from the glibness of your tongue, but there is no good sense in your words. A headstrong man who is powerful and eloquent proves to be a bad citizen because he is wanting in intelligence. This new divinity whom you laugh at—I could not begin to tell you how great he will become throughout Hellas. . . .⁶ (266–274)

Pentheus, believe me; do not be overly confident that force is all-powerful in human affairs, and do not think that you are wise when the attitude that you hold is sick. Receive the god into the city, pour him libations, crown your head, and celebrate his worship. (309–313) 80

Tiresias goes on to argue that self-control is a question of one's own nature and character. Dionysus is not immoral; he cannot corrupt a chaste woman or restrain a promiscuous one. Besides, the god (just like Pentheus himself) is happy to receive the homage of his people.

Cadmus reinforces Tiresias' appeal for reason and control. Pentheus must be sick to defy the god; and even if he were right and Dionysus were an impostor, he should be willing to compromise and lie in order to save the honor of Semele and the whole family. But Pentheus is young and adamant; he accuses his peers of folly and madness and directs one of his henchmen to smash Tiresias' place of augury (after all, has he not himself desecrated his own priestly office?) and to hunt down the effeminate foreigner who has corrupted the women of Thebes.

A guard brings in the exotic stranger who has come with his new religion (in reality, he is Dionysus himself), and Euripides presents the first of three interviews

between the god and the man which turn upon the ironic reversal of their positions. Pentheus, believing himself triumphant, is gradually but inevitably caught in the net prepared for him by Dionysus. The calm and sure strength of the god plays beautifully upon the neurotic impulsiveness of the mortal (434–518):

Guard: Pentheus, here we are, having hunted the quarry you sent us after, and our efforts have not been unsuccessful. But we found this wild beast tame—he did not attempt to flee but gave me his hands willingly; he did not even turn pale but kept the flush of wine in his cheeks. With a smile he bade me tie him up and lead him away and waited for me, thus making my task easy. I was taken aback and said: “O stranger, I do not arrest you of my own free will but at the orders of Pentheus who has sent me.” (434–442)

About the Bacchae whom you seized and bound and imprisoned—they are freed and have gone and dance about the glens calling on their god, Bacchus. The bonds fell from their feet of their own accord, and the locks on the door gave way untouched by mortal hands. This man who has come to our city of Thebes is full of many miraculous wonders—and what else will happen is your concern, not mine. (443–450) 10

PENTHEUS: Untie his hands. Now that he is in my trap, he is not nimble enough to escape me. Well, stranger, you are not unattractive physically—at least to women—and, after all, your purpose in Thebes is to lure them. Your flowing locks that ripple down your cheeks so seductively prove that you are no wrestler. Your fair complexion too is cultivated by avoiding the rays of the sun and by keeping in the shade so that you may ensnare Aphrodite with your beauty. But first tell me where you come from. (451–460) 20

DIONYSUS: I can answer your question easily and simply. I am sure you have heard of the mountain of Tmolus with its flowers.

PENTHEUS: I have; its range encircles the city of Sardis.

DIONYSUS: I am from there; Lydia is my fatherland.

PENTHEUS: How is it that you bring these mysteries of yours to Hellas? (465)

DIONYSUS: Dionysus, the son of Zeus, has directed me.

PENTHEUS: Is there a Zeus in Lydia who begets new gods?

DIONYSUS: No, he is the same Zeus who wedded Semele here in Thebes.

PENTHEUS: Did he bend you to his service, an apparition in the night, or did you really see him with your own eyes? 30

DIONYSUS: We saw each other face to face, and he gave me his secrets. (470)

PENTHEUS: What is the nature of these secrets of yours?

DIONYSUS: It is not lawful for the uninitiated to know them.

PENTHEUS: What advantage is there for those who do participate?

DIONYSUS: It is not right for you to learn this, but the knowledge is worth much.

PENTHEUS: Your answer is clever, designed to make me want to hear more. (475)

DIONYSUS: An impious man is abhorred by the god and his mysteries.

PENTHEUS: You say that you saw the god clearly; well then, what did he look like? 40

DIONYSUS: He looked as he wished; I had no control over his appearance.

PENTHEUS: Once again you have sidetracked me cleverly with an answer that says nothing.

DIONYSUS: The words of the wise seem foolish to the ignorant. (480)

PENTHEUS: Have you come here first of all to introduce your god?



Audio

DIONYSUS: Every foreigner already dances his rituals.
 PENTHEUS: Yes, of course, for they are far inferior to Hellenes.
 DIONYSUS: Customs differ, but in these rituals the foreigners are superior.
 PENTHEUS: Do you perform your holy rites by night or by day? (485)
 DIONYSUS: By night for the most part; darkness adds to the solemnity. 50
 PENTHEUS: For women it is treacherous and corrupt.
 DIONYSUS: One may find, if one looks for it, shameful behavior by daylight too.
 PENTHEUS: You must be punished for your evil sophistries.
 DIONYSUS: And you for your ignorance and blasphemy against the god. (490)
 PENTHEUS: How bold our Bacchant is and how facile his retorts.
 DIONYSUS: What punishment must I suffer? What terrible thing will you do to me?
 PENTHEUS: First I shall cut your pretty locks.
 DIONYSUS: My hair is sacred; it belongs to the god.
 PENTHEUS: Hand over your thyrsus then. (495) 60
 DIONYSUS: Take it away from me yourself. I carry it for Dionysus; it really belongs to him.
 PENTHEUS: I shall close you up in a prison.
 DIONYSUS: The god himself will free me, whenever I wish.
 PENTHEUS: As you call on him when you take your stand amid your Bacchic women, I suppose.
 DIONYSUS: Even now he is near at hand and sees what I endure. (500)
 PENTHEUS: Where is he? My eyes cannot see him.
 DIONYSUS: Here with me. But you in your blasphemy cannot perceive him for yourself. 70
 PENTHEUS: Guards, seize him; he is making a fool of me and of all Thebes.
 DIONYSUS: I tell you not to bind me—I am the sane one, not you.
 PENTHEUS: My orders are to bind you, and I have the upper hand. (505)
 DIONYSUS: You do not know what life you live, what you do, or who you are.
 PENTHEUS: I am Pentheus, the son of Agave; my father is Echion.
 DIONYSUS: Your name, Pentheus, which means sorrow, is appropriate for the doom that will be yours.
 PENTHEUS: Get out of here—Guards, imprison him in the neighboring stables where he may find his secret darkness—do your mystic dances there. And the women you have brought with you as accomplices in your evil I shall either keep 80 as slaves myself to work the loom or sell them to others—this will stop their hands from beating out their din on tambourines. (509–514)
 DIONYSUS: I will go, since what is not destined to be, I am not destined to suffer. But Dionysus, who you say does not exist, will exact vengeance for your insolence. For as you do me wrong and imprison me, you do the same to him. (515–518)

Pentheus confidently follows Dionysus into the prison. But the god miraculously frees himself amid fire, earthquake, and the destruction of the entire palace. He explains to the chorus how he has escaped from Pentheus' evil clutches, maintaining throughout the fiction of his role as the god's disciple. Quite typically Dionysus is associated with or transformed into an animal (616–636):

DIONYSUS: I have made a fool of Pentheus—he thought that he was tying me up, yet he did not so much as lay a finger on me but fed on empty hopes. In

the chamber where he led me a prisoner, he found a bull. It was the knees and hoofs of this animal that he tried to bind, fuming and raging, biting his lips, and dripping with sweat, while I sat calmly close by his side and watched. In this crisis Bacchus arrived and made the building shake and raised a flame up from the tomb of his mother. When Pentheus saw it, he thought that the palace was on fire and rushed this way and that, calling on the servants to bring water. The entire household joined in the work, but their toil was for nothing. Pentheus, thinking that I had got away, abandoned his efforts and seized a dark sword and rushed inside the palace in pursuit. (616–628) 10

Then Dionysus created an illusion in the courtyard (I am telling you what I believe happened), and Pentheus made a dash for it, jabbing and stabbing at the sunny air, imagining he was butchering me. Bacchus had even greater humiliation for him than this. He razed the whole palace to the ground; all lies shattered for him as he beholds the most bitter results of my imprisonment. Worn out and exhausted, he has dropped his sword; a mere mortal, he dared to go to battle against a god. (629–636)

As Dionysus coolly finishes his account, Pentheus appears, bewildered, angry, and, despite his experience, still relentlessly aggressive. A brief exchange between the two is interrupted by the arrival of a messenger, who reports what he and others have seen of the Bacchic women and their worship in the mountains; at first a calm, peaceful scene full of miracles, then madness and bloodshed when the interlopers are detected—a grim foreshadowing of what is in store for Pentheus (677–774):

MESSANGER: I had just reached the hill country with my pasturing herds by the time that the sun had risen and was warming the earth with its rays. And I saw the women, who had arranged themselves in three groups; Autonoë led one, your mother, Agave, the second, and Ino, the third. All were stretched out asleep, some reclined on beds of fir, others rested their heads on oak leaves, having flung themselves down at random but with modesty; and they were not, as you said they would be, intoxicated with wine and the music of the flute, bent on satisfying their lust in solitary places. (677–688)

When your mother heard the sounds of our horned cattle, she stood up in the midst of the Bacchae, and cried out to rouse them from their sleep, and they threw off the heavy slumber from their eyes and jumped up—amazing in their orderliness, young and old (many still unwed). The first thing they did was to loosen their hair to their shoulders and tie up their fawnskins if any of the fastenings had come loose; and they made a belt for the dappled fur with snakes that licked their cheeks. Some held in their arms the young of the wild, a gazelle or wolf cubs, and those who had left their newborn babes at home gave them white milk from breasts that were still full. (689–702) 10

And they put on crowns of ivy, oak, and flowering vine. One took her thyrsus and struck it against a rock, and from it a gush of dewy water welled up; another hit the solid earth with her wand, and from the spot the god sent forth a spring of wine. Those who thirsted for milk scraped the earth with their fingertips and produced white streams; and from each thyrsus, wreathed in ivy, dripped sweet drops of honey. And so, if you had been there to see these things, you would have invoked with prayers the god whom you now blame. (702–713) 20



Dionysus, Maenads, and Satyrs. Attic black-figure kylix by Nikosthenes, ca. 520 B.C. Dionysus sits on a square chair on the right, holding a rhyton (a drinking horn with a hole in the narrow end through which the wine flowed) in his right hand, with a stylized crown or garland on his head. Around the kylix are dancing ithyphallic satyrs and maenads. Note the double “flute” (a reed instrument) played by the satyr to the left of Dionysus, and the wine jug in the left hand of the maenad to the right of Dionysus. The scene is decorated with trailing vine-leaves and clusters of grapes: in the center is a running winged Gorgon. (© RMN (Musée du Louvre)/Hervé Lewandowski)

We herdsmen and shepherds gathered together to discuss and argue about the strange and wondrous actions. One of the group, who always goes into town and has a way with words, spoke to us all: “You who inhabit the sacred mountain heights, how would you like to hunt down Agave, the mother of Pentheus, in her revels and do the king a favor?” What he said seemed good to us, so we hid ourselves in a leafy thicket and waited in ambush. At the appointed time they began their Bacchic revels, shaking their thyrsus and calling on the god, the son of Zeus, with one voice “Iacchus, Bromius!” The whole mountain and animals joined in their ecstasy and there was nothing that remained unmoved by the dance. (714–727) 30

It happened that Agave, as she leaped and ran, came close to me, and I leaped out of the ambush where I had hidden myself, bent on seizing her. But she cried aloud: “O my swift-running hounds, we are being hunted by these men; so follow me, follow, armed with your thyrsus in your hands.” (728–733)

And so we fled and escaped being torn into pieces by the Bacchae, but with their bare hands they attacked our cattle grazing on the grass. You could see one of them wrenching apart a bellowing cow, its udders full. Others ripped apart the calves, and you could see ribs and cloven hoofs being scattered high 40

and low, and from the pines the pieces hung dripping with blood. Bulls, arrogant before as they raged with their horns, were laid low, dragged bodily to the ground by the countless hands of girls; and their flesh was stripped from their bodies more quickly than you, O king, could wink your eyes. (734–747)

Like birds propelled aloft by the speed of their course, the Bacchae ranged across the stretch of plain along the stream of the Asopus, which affords the Thebans a rich harvest. Like a hostile army they descended upon the villages of Hysiae and Erythrae, nestled low on the slopes of Cithaeron, and devastated them. They snatched children from their homes, and all the booty (including bronze and iron) that they carried off on their shoulders did not fall onto the dark earth, although it was not fastened. They bore fire on their hair and it did not burn. The villagers, enraged by the plundering of the Bacchae, rushed to arms. (748–759)

Then, my king, there was a terrifying sight to behold. The weapons that the villagers threw did not draw any blood, but when the Bacchae hurled the thyrsus from their hands they inflicted wounds on many. Women routed men—a feat not to be accomplished without the power of some god. Back they came to where they sallied forth, to the very streams which the god made gush for them. They washed their hands of blood, and snakes licked the stains from their cheeks. (760–768)

And so, my lord, receive into the city this god, whoever he is. He is great in many respects but especially in his reputed gift to mortals, about which I have heard, the grape, our remedy for pain and sorrow. With no more wine, there could be no more love and no other pleasure for humankind besides. (769–774)

Pentheus refuses to listen to the pleas of the messenger. He is determined to make an armed assault on the Bacchae. But the stranger, Dionysus, finds a way to restrain him by appealing to Pentheus' basic nature and psychology—in general, the complex neurosis that stems from his repressions; in particular, his prurient preoccupation with sex and his desire to see the orgies that he insists are taking place (811–861):

DIONYSUS: Would you like to see the women banded together in the mountains? (811)

PENTHEUS: Yes, indeed. I would give a ton of gold for that.

DIONYSUS: Why are you driven by such a great desire to see them?

PENTHEUS: Actually, it would pain me to see them drunk.

DIONYSUS: Nevertheless, you would be pleased to see what is painful to you? (815)

PENTHEUS: To be sure, if I watched in silence crouched beneath the firs.

DIONYSUS: But they will track you down, even if you go in secret.

PENTHEUS: Then I shall go openly; what you say is right.

DIONYSUS: You will undergo the journey then? Let me lead you.

PENTHEUS: Come, as quickly as possible; I begrudge you this delay. (820)

DIONYSUS: Then dress up in a fine linen robe.

PENTHEUS: What is this? Am I to change from a man to a woman?

DIONYSUS: If you are seen there as a man, they will kill you.

PENTHEUS: Again, what you say is right. You are like some sage of long ago.

DIONYSUS: Dionysus gives me this inspiration. (825)

PENTHEUS: How may what you advise best be accomplished?

DIONYSUS: I will go inside and dress you up there.
 PENTHEUS: In the garb of a woman? But shame holds me back! 20
 DIONYSUS: You are no longer interested in watching the Maenads?
 PENTHEUS: What dress did you say that you would put on me? (830)
 DIONYSUS: I shall set on your head a long flowing wig.
 PENTHEUS: And what is the next feature of my outfit?
 DIONYSUS: A robe that falls to your feet and a band around your head.
 PENTHEUS: What else will you give me?
 DIONYSUS: A thyrsus in your hand and a dappled fawnskin cloak. (835)
 PENTHEUS: I cannot bring myself to put on the costume of a woman.
 DIONYSUS: But if you attack the Bacchae in battle, you will shed blood.
 PENTHEUS: This is true; I must first go as a spy. 30
 DIONYSUS: To be sure, it is wiser than to hunt out evil by evil.
 PENTHEUS: How shall I get out of the city without being seen? (840)
 DIONYSUS: We shall take a deserted route, and I shall lead the way.
 PENTHEUS: Anything, rather than have the Bacchae laugh at me. I shall go into
 the house and make preparations that are for the best.
 DIONYSUS: So be it, and I am at your side ready for everything.
 PENTHEUS: I am going inside; I shall either proceed with arms or follow your
 instructions. (845–846)
 DIONYSUS: Women, this man is ready to be caught in the net. He will go to the
 Bacchae, and he will pay the penalty with his life. Dionysus, now do your work; 40
 for you are not far away. We shall exact our retribution. First we shall inflict upon
 him delirious madness and drive him out of his wits; in his right mind, he would
 not want to dress up in the costume of a woman; but once driven from reason
 he will put it on. My desire is to make him the laughingstock of the Thebans as
 they see him led in a woman's garb through the city in return for the terrible
 threats that he uttered before. I go now to deck out Pentheus in the dress with
 which he will go down to the realm of Hades, slaughtered by the hands of his
 mother. He will know Dionysus as the son of Zeus and a deity of his own right,
 among humankind most dread and most gentle. (847–861)

The dressing of Pentheus in the garb of the Bacchae suggests the ceremonial decking out of the sacrificial victim. By the ritual of donning his costume, Pentheus falls under the spell and the power of the god, eventually to be offered up to him. The chorus sings of the joys of their worship and the justice of their triumph over impiety; and at the end of their song, Dionysus exerts final and complete mastery over Pentheus, who is delirious (912–970):

DIONYSUS: Pentheus, I call on you, the one who desires to see what he should
 not see and hastens upon what he should not do. Come forward out of the
 house, let me behold you dressed in the garb of a woman, a Bacchic Maenad,
 about to go as a spy on your mother and her group. (912–917)
 PENTHEUS: I think that I see two suns, and the image of Thebes with its seven
 gates appears double. You look like a bull as you lead me forward, with horns
 growing out of your head. Were you then an animal? Now, indeed, you have
 become a bull. (918–922)
 DIONYSUS: The god walks with us; he is on our side. although he was not
 kindly disposed before. Now you see what you should see. 10
 PENTHEUS: Tell me how I look. Do I not have the bearing of Ino or my mother,
 Agave?

DIONYSUS: Looking at you, I seem to see those very two. But this lock here that I had fixed under your hairband has fallen out of place. (927–929)

PENTHEUS: I shook it loose indoors while I was tossing my head back and forth like a Bacchic reveler.

DIONYSUS: Well we, whose concern is to serve you, shall put it back in place. Bend your head. (932–933)

PENTHEUS: Fine, you deck me out properly, for I am now dedicated to you.

DIONYSUS: Your belt is loose and the folds of your dress do not hang straight 10
to your ankles.

PENTHEUS: They are not straight at the right foot, but here on the left the dress hangs well at the heel. (937–938)

DIONYSUS: You will, I am sure, consider me the best of your friends, when contrary to your expectation you witness the temperance of the Bacchae.

PENTHEUS: Shall I be more like one of the Bacchae if I hold my thyrsus in my right or my left hand? (941–942)

DIONYSUS: You should hold it in your right hand, and raise it and your right foot at the same time.

PENTHEUS: Will I be able to lift up on my shoulders Mt. Cithaeron with its 30
glens full of Bacchae? (945–946)

DIONYSUS: You will, if you wish; before your mind was not sound, but now it is as it ought to be.

PENTHEUS: Let us take crowbars, or shall I thrust my shoulder or my arm under the peaks and crush them with my hands?

DIONYSUS: Do not destroy the haunts of the nymphs and the places where Pan does his piping. (951–952)

PENTHEUS: Your words are right; women must not be overcome by force; I will hide myself among the firs.

DIONYSUS: You will find the hiding place that you should, coming upon the 40
Maenads as a crafty spy. (955–956)

PENTHEUS: Indeed, I can see them now in the bushes like birds held fast in the enticing coils of love.

DIONYSUS: Yes, of course, you go on a mission to guard against this very thing. Maybe you will catch them, if you yourself are not caught first.

PENTHEUS: Take me through the middle of Thebes, for I am the only man among them who dares this deed. (961–962)

DIONYSUS: You alone bear the burden of toil for this city—you alone. And so the struggle which must be awaits you. Follow me; I shall lead you there in safety, but another will lead you back. 50

PENTHEUS: My mother. (966)

DIONYSUS: A spectacle for all.

PENTHEUS: It is for this I am going.

DIONYSUS: You will be carried home.

PENTHEUS: What luxury you are suggesting.

DIONYSUS: In the hands of your mother. (969)

PENTHEUS: You insist upon pampering me.

DIONYSUS: Pampering of sorts.

PENTHEUS: Worthy of such rewards, I follow you. (970)

Pentheus imagines he will return in a splendid carriage, with his mother by his side. This terrifying scene is built on more than this one irony and is laden

with a multiplicity of ambiguities. Pentheus the transvestite imagines, like a child, loving care at the hands of his mother. How bitter now appear the earlier taunts of Pentheus against Cadmus and Tiresias! In his delirium, does Pentheus really see the god in his true and basic character—a beast? Or does his vision spring from his own warped interpretation of the bestial nature of the worship?

Ambiguity, very much a part of the Dionysian experience, runs throughout the play. In the description of the Bacchae we hear two stories, one of serenity and tranquility on the mountains, where man and nature are in harmony, another of unnatural acts and violent and bloody sacrifice. Dionysus himself is both gentle and terrifying, powerless and potent, a giver of joy and pain. Pentheus' vision is confused, when he sees within the same person a bull and the smiling figure of a man. In the end, Pentheus becomes the hunter and the hunted, an adversary of the god and a devotee, concerned with the proper dress and carriage of a bacchant. He who wanted to see will be seen. He who wanted to battle a god will be possessed by him and become his sacrificial victim.

A messenger arrives to tell of Pentheus' horrifying death (1043–1152):



Audio

MESSANGER: When we had left the town of Thebes behind and crossed the stream of the Asopus, we made our way up the slopes of Cithaeron, Pentheus and I (for I followed with my master) and the stranger who led us to the scene. (1043–1047)

First we took a position in a grassy glen, with silent footsteps and not a word, so that we might see and not be seen. It was a valley surrounded by cliffs, watered by streams, and shaded by pines; here Maenads sat, their hands occupied in their joyous tasks. Some were restoring a crown of ivy on a thyrsus that had lost its foliage; others, happy as fillies let loose from their painted yokes, were singing Bacchic hymns in answering refrains. (1048–1057)

But poor Pentheus, who could not see this crowd of women, said: "My friend, from where I stand I am too far away to see these counterfeit Maenads clearly, but if I climbed up a towering pine on the hillside, I could properly behold the orgies of the Maenads." Then and there I saw the stranger do wondrous things. He took hold of the very top branch of a pine that reached up to the sky and pulled it down, down, down to the black earth. And it was bent like a bow or the curving line of the circle of a wheel. Thus the stranger grabbed the mountain pine with his hands and bent it to the ground, a feat no mortal could accomplish. (1058–1069)

He sat Pentheus on the topmost branches and let the tree go, sliding it through his hands until it was upright again, slowly and carefully so that he might not dislodge him. It towered straight to towering heaven, with our king perched on top. He could be seen more clearly by the Maenads than he could see them. He was just becoming visible, seated aloft, when the stranger was no longer to be seen, and from heaven a voice (I imagine that of Dionysus) cried aloud: "O women, I bring the man who made a mockery of you and me and our mysteries; now take vengeance on him." (1070–1081)

As the voice spoke these words, a blaze of holy fire flashed between heaven and earth. The air grew still, every leaf in the wooded glen stood silent, and no sound of a beast was to be heard. The women had not made out the voice clearly, and they stood up straight and looked around. He called again, and when the daughters of Cadmus understood the clear command of Bacchus, they rushed forth as swift as doves in their relentless course, his mother, Agave, her sisters, and all the Bacchae. With a madness inspired by the breath of the

god, they darted over the glen with its streams and rocks. When they saw the king seated in the pine tree, they first climbed on the rock cliff that towered opposite and hurled stones at him with all their might and pelted him with branches of pines. Others hurled the thyrsus through the air at Pentheus, a pitiable target. (1082–1100)

But they were unsuccessful, for the poor wretch sat trapped and helpless, 40 too high for even their fanaticism. Finally, with a lightning force they ripped off oak branches and tried to use them as levers to uproot the tree. But when these efforts too were all in vain, Agave exclaimed: “Come, O Maenads, stand around the tree in a circle and grab hold of it, so that we may catch the climbing beast and prevent him from revealing the secret revels of the god.” And they applied a thousand hands and tore up the tree out of the earth. And from his lofty seat, Pentheus fell hurtling to the ground with endless cries; for he knew what evil fate was near. (1100–1113)

His mother as priestess was the first to begin the slaughter. She fell on him, 50 and he ripped off the band from his hair so that poor Agave might recognize him and not kill him, and he cried out as he touched her cheek: “Mother, it is your son, Pentheus, whom you bore in the home of Echion. Have pity on me for my sins and do not kill me, your son.” (1114–1121)

But Agave was not in her right senses; her mouth foamed, and her eyes rolled madly as the god Bacchus held her in his power. And Pentheus could not



Pentheus. Attic red-figure kylix by Douris, ca. 480 B.C. This drinking cup graphically depicts the dismemberment of Pentheus. The maenads on either side of Pentheus, wearing spotted animal skins, are wrenching his body apart. The maenad at which Pentheus seems to be gazing pleadingly has been identified as Agave. Others have been identified as Autonoë and Ino. The maenad at the far left is holding one of his limbs. At the right a satyr, with arms raised in excitement, is observing the sparagmos (the sacrificial rending of the victim). On the opposite side of the vase, between two maenads holding parts of Pentheus' body and unnervingly staring directly out at the viewer, sits Dionysus, enjoying his wine to the music of another satyr playing a double flute. On the tondo (within the center of the cup) is a swaying maenad holding a live leopard in one hand and a thyrsos in the other. (Kimbell Art Museum, Fort Worth, Texas/Art Resource, NY)

reach her. She seized his left arm below the elbow and placing her foot against the ribs of her ill-fated son, wrenched his arm out of his shoulder. It was not done through her own strength, but the god made it easy for her hands. From the other side, Ino clawed and tore at his flesh, and Autonoe and the whole pack converged on him. All shouted together, he moaning with what breath remained, they screaming in triumph. One carried an arm, another a foot with the boot still on; his ribs were stripped clean, and they all with blood-drenched hands tossed the flesh of Pentheus among them like a ball. His body lies scattered, some pieces under hard rocks, others in the shady depths of the woods—not easy to find. (1122–1139) 60

His mother has taken his poor head and affixed it on the point of her thyrsus; she carries it like that of a mountain lion through the depths of Cithaeron, leaving her sisters and their Maenad bands. She comes within these walls, exulting in her ill-fated prey and calling on Bacchus, her partner in the hunt, her comrade in the chase, her champion of victory, who gave her tears as her reward. And so I am leaving now, before Agave reaches the palace, to get away from this misfortune. Temperance and reverence for the gods are best, the wisest possessions, I believe, that exist for mortals who will use them. (1139–1152) 70

Agave returns and in a terrifying scene with her father Cadmus, she awakens from her madness to recognize the horror of her deed; it is the head of her son Pentheus, not that of a mountain lion that she holds in her hands. The conclusion of the play affirms the divine power of Dionysus. He appears now as god, the *deus ex machina*, to mete out his harsh justice against those who have denied his godhead and blasphemed his religion.

Pentheus has already died for his crimes; the other principal sinners must go into exile. Cadmus and Harmonia will experience much war and suffering in their wanderings and will be turned into serpents; but eventually they will be saved by Ares (the father of Harmonia) and transported to the Islands of the Blessed. Agave and her sisters must leave Thebes immediately. In her anguished farewell to her father, she utters this provocative commentary on her bitter and tragic experience with the religion of Dionysus.

May I reach a place where Cithaeron, that mountain polluted by blood, may never see me or I lay eyes upon it, where any record of the thyrsus is unknown. Let Cithaeron and the thyrsus be the concern of other Bacchic women, not me. (1383–1387)

There are serious textual problems in the last section of the play. A medieval work, the *Christus Patiens*, which drew upon Euripides, is of some help—an interesting fact that rivets our attention to the parallels between Dionysus and Christ.

The pathos and horror of the butchering of Pentheus have led some to advance a sympathetic view of the rash king as an ascetic martyr, killed in his crusade against the irrational tide of religious fanaticism. But too much in the makeup of this young man suggests the myopic psychopath who is unable to accept human nature as it is and foolishly tries to suppress it. The basic impulses toward both the bestial and the sublime are terrifyingly and wondrously inter-related; Dionysus is, after all, the god of mob fury and religious ecstasy and anything in between. Was the celebration of his worship a cry for release from

Harry Partch's American Bacchae

Harry Partch, the American composer, offers enlightening insights into elements of Dionysiac worship in his elucidation of his musical and theatrical Americanization of Euripides' tragedy, *Revelation in the Courthouse Park* (1960):

I first decided that I would bodily transfer Euripides' The Bacchae to an American setting. But in the end the better solution seemed to be to alternate scenes between an American courthouse park and the area before the palace of the city of Thebes. . . . I was determined to make this an American here-and-now drama, which, tragically, it truly is. . . . Many years ago I was struck by a strong and strange similarity between the basic situation in the Euripides play and at least two phenomena of present-day America. Religious rituals with a strong sexual element are not unknown to our culture, nor are sex rituals with a strong religious element. (I assume that the mobbing of young male singers by semihysterical women is recognizable as a sex ritual for a godhead.) And these separate phenomena, after years of observing them, have become synthesized as a single kind of ritual with religion and sex in equal parts, and with deep roots in an earlier period of evolution.⁷

The equation of the idolization of Elvis Presley with the worship of Dionysus has turned out to be more apt than Partch might even suspect. For the devout, Elvis either has never really died or has been resurrected, and he is still very much with us. Pilgrimages to his temple in Graceland are legion. The Dionysiac experience in relation to singers of popular music and rock has spanned more than one generation. It can be recognized in the bobby-soxers who swooned at the feet of Frank Sinatra and in the androgynous cults of Michael Jackson and Boy George, and it afflicts both sexes with equal passion. The furor aroused by the female singer Madonna or the rock group The Beatles devastates men and women equally, sometimes enhanced by the Dionysiac use of intoxicating drugs (see also the section on Harry Partch in Chapter 28 on the companion website). Every generation has its new idols.

the restraints of civilized society and a return to the mystic purity and abounding freedom of nature, or was it merely a deceptive excuse for self-indulgence in an orgy of undisciplined passion?

Other Opponents of Dionysus

At Tiryns in Argos the **daughters of King Proetus** resisted Dionysus, who caused them to rush over the countryside, leaving their homes and killing their children. In return for half of the kingdom, the famous seer **Melampus**, who, according to Herodotus (2.29) introduced the rituals of Dionysus to Greece, cured the madness of the daughters of Proetus by means of herbs and therapeutic dances.⁸ He joined a group of strong young men in performing a kind of war dance, although one daughter, Iphinoë, died during the pursuit. This myth was connected with the festival of the Agriania, which involved a ritual pursuit of women by night and a return the next day to the normal order of society. It was celebrated at Orchomenus and at many other places in Greece.

In Orchomenus, a city of Boeotia, the **daughters of Minyas** refused to participate in Bacchic worship but remained at home to weave. Dionysus, in the guise of a girl, warned them of their folly to no avail, and they were driven mad. One of them, Leucippe, bore a son named Hippasus, who (like Pentheus) was torn to pieces. Unlike the daughters of Proetus, the Minyads did not return to normal life. They became winged creatures of the night, either owls or bats. Clymene, however, one of the daughters of Minyas, appears as the wife of five different husbands and thus becomes both the aunt of Jason (through her marriage to Pheres) and the mother (by Iasus) of Atalanta. She also was loved by Helius to become the mother of Phaëthon.

Lycurgus of Thrace pursued the nurses of Dionysus with an ox goad, and Dionysus himself in terror jumped into the sea and was rescued and comforted by Thetis. The gods became angry with Lycurgus, and Zeus struck him with blindness and he died soon afterward.

The Nature of Dionysus, His Retinue, and His Religion

The *Homeric Hymn to Dionysus* (1)⁹ gives some variant information about Dionysus' birth, derives his name from Zeus (Dios) and the mountain Nysa (which is here placed in Egypt), and establishes the universal power of his worship.

O divinely born god, sewn in Zeus' thigh,¹⁰ some say it was on Dracenum, some in windy Icarus, some at the deep flowing Alpheus,¹¹ where Semele, made pregnant by Zeus who delights in the lightning, gave birth to you. Others say, O lord, that you were born in Thebes. They are all wrong; the father of both gods and men gave you birth, away from people and hidden from white-armed Hera. 10

There is a certain mountain, Nysa, very high and with verdant forests, far from Phoenicia, near the streams of Egypt.¹² (8–9)

“... and they will set up many statues in temples; and as things are three, mortals always, everywhere, will sacrifice perfect hecatombs to you in triennial festivals.”¹³ The son of Cronus spoke and nodded with his dark brows; and the divine hair of our lord flowed down around his immortal head and he made great Olympus shake. Thus speaking, wise Zeus nodded confirmation with his head. (10–16) 10

Be kind, you, sewn in Zeus' thigh, who drive women mad. We bards sing of you as we begin and end our song. It is utterly impossible for anyone who is forgetful of you to remember how to sing his holy song. (17–19)

So hail to you, Dionysus, sewn in Zeus' thigh, along with your mother, Semele, whom indeed they call Thyone. (20–21)

Another *Homeric Hymn to Dionysus* (26) tells us more about the god:

I begin to sing about ivy-crowned, loud-crying Dionysus, glorious son of Zeus and renowned Semele. The nymphs with beautiful hair took him to their bosoms from the lord his father and nurtured him tenderly in the vales of Mt. Nysa. By the grace of his father, he grew up in a fragrant cave, to be counted among the immortals. But when the goddesses had brought up this much-hymned god, then indeed he used to wander, heavily wreathed in ivy and laurel, among the

woodland haunts of the forest. The nymphs followed along, with him as leader, and the sound of their cries filled the vast forest. (1–10)

So hail to you, Dionysus, rich in grape clusters; grant that we may in our joy go through these seasons again and again for many years.

10

For a translation of Demosthenes' taunts about Dionysiac worship, see www.oup.com/us/morford.

The essential characteristics of Dionysiac religion are an ecstatic spiritual release through music and dance,¹⁴ the possession by the god of his followers, the rending apart of the sacrificial animal, and the eating of the raw flesh (**omophagy**, a kind of ritual communion, since the god was believed to be present in the victim). The religious congregation (the holy **thiasus**) was divided into groups, often with a male leader for each, who played the role of the god. The Bacchae, or **maenads**, are the female devotees, mortal women who become possessed. In mythology they are more than human, nymphs rather than mere mortals.

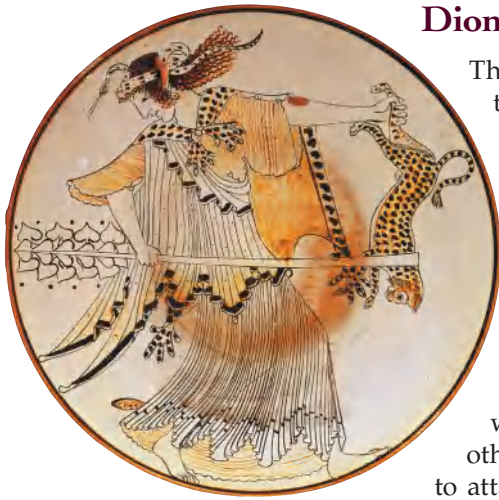
Their mythological male counterparts are **satyrs**, who, like them, are spirits of nature; they, however, are not completely human but part man and part animal, possessing various attributes of a horse or a goat—a horse's tail and ears, a goat's beard and horns—although in the later periods they are often depicted as considerably more humanized. Satyrs dance and sing and love music; they make wine and drink it, and they are perpetually in a state of sexual excitement. One of their favorite sports is to chase maenads through the woods. Animal skins and garlands are traditional attributes of Bacchic revelers (although satyrs are usually nude); maenads, in particular, carry the thyrsus, a pole wreathed with ivy or vine leaves, pointed at the top to receive a pine cone. As we have seen, it is a magic wand that evokes miracles, but if necessary it can be converted into a deadly weapon.

Sileni also attend Dionysus; they often cannot be distinguished from satyrs, although some of them are older (*papposileni*) and even more lecherous. Yet others are old and wise, like **Silenus** himself, the tutor of Dionysus. A story tells how once one of them was made drunk by drinking water from a spring laced with wine; when he was brought to **King Midas**, this Silenus philosophized that the best fate for human beings was not to be born at all and that the next best was to die as soon as possible after birth, providing a typical example of Greek pessimism and wisdom reminiscent of Solon and Herodotus.¹⁵ Dionysus and his retinue are favorite subjects in Greek art.

As the male god of vegetation, Dionysus was, as we should expect, associated with a fertility goddess; his mother, Semele, was a full-fledged earth deity in her own right before she became Hellenized. The story of Zeus' birth on Crete, with the attendants who drowned out his infant cries by their frenzied music, suggests contamination with Dionysiac ritual. Certainly, Euripides associates Bacchic mysticism with the ritual worship of both Rhea and Cybele. Dionysus' "marriage" with Ariadne, saving her after she was deserted by Theseus on the island of Naxos (see pp. 594–596), not only provides an example of the union of the male and female powers of vegetation but also illustrates allegorically his powers of redemption. Dionysus represents the sap of life, the coursing of the blood through the veins, the throbbing excitement and mystery of sex and of nature; thus he is a god of ecstasy and mysticism.



Dionysus and Satyrs. Red-figure kylix, by the Brygos painter, ca. 480 B.C. Some 200 vases have been attributed to this painter, who is best known for the liveliness of the poses and the exquisite rendering of the figures, particularly their faces. Here we see a Bacchic revel with Dionysus, wreathed with ivy, playing a lyre and throwing his head back with remarkable abandon. He is flanked by two typically Attic satyrs: balding, snub nosed, with goat's beard, but with the tail and ears of a horse. The satyr on the right wears the familiar dappled leopard skin. The satyr on the left holds a vine branch with leaves, forming the background. Both satyrs are dancing around the god with castanets.



Maenad. Interior of an Attic kylix by the Brygos painter, ca. 480 B.C.; diameter 11 ¼ in. This lively white-ground painting (the cup is signed by the potter Brygos) shows a maenad in violent motion, holding a thyrsus in her right hand and a small leopard in her left. A leopardskin is fastened over her dress, and a wreath of serpents encircles her head. (Erich Lessing/*Art Resource*, NY)

Dionysus Spiritualized as Zagreus

The essence and spirit of Greek drama are to be found in the emotional environment of Dionysiac ecstasy. Theories concerning the origins of this genre in its relationship to Dionysus are legion. But it is a fact that tragedy and comedy were performed at Athens in a festival in his honor. It is difficult to agree with those who feel that this connection was purely accidental. Certainly, Aristotle's treatise dealing with the nature of tragedy in terms of a catharsis of pity and fear takes for granted emotions and excitement that are essentially Bacchic.¹⁶

Another myth told about his birth even more clearly established Dionysus in this role as a god of the mysteries. Zeus mated with his daughter Persephone, who bore a son, Zagreus, which is another name for Dionysus. In her jealousy, Hera then aroused the Titans to attack the child. These monstrous beings, their faces whitened with chalk, attacked the infant as he was looking in a mirror (in another version, they beguiled him with toys and cut him to pieces with knives). After the murder, the Titans devoured the dismembered corpse.¹⁷ But the heart of the infant god was saved and brought to Zeus by Athena, and Dionysus was born again—swallowed by Zeus and begotten on Semele. Zeus was angry with the Titans and destroyed them with his thunder and lightning; but from their ashes humankind was born.

Surely, this is one of the most significant myths in terms of the religious dogma that it provides. By this myth human beings are endowed with a dual nature—a body gross and evil (since we are sprung from the Titans) and a soul that is pure and divine (for after all the Titans had devoured the god). Thus basic religious concepts (which lie at the root of all mystery religions) are accounted for: sin, immortality, resurrection, life after death, reward, and punishment. It is no accident that Dionysus is linked with Orpheus and Demeter and the message they preached. He is in his person a resurrection-god; the story is told that he went down into the realm of the dead and brought back his mother, who in this account is usually given the name Thyone.

Dionysus, Icarius, and Erigone

Dionysus, however, can be received amid peace and joy, although even then tragedy might result. In Attica, in the days of King Pandion, a man named Icarius was most hospitable to the god, and as a reward he was given the gift of wine. But when the people first felt the effects of this blessing, they thought they had been poisoned, and they turned upon Icarius and killed him. Erigone, his devoted daughter, accompanied by her dog Maira, searched everywhere for her father. When she found him, she hanged herself in grief. Suffering and plague ensued for the people until, upon Apollo's advice, they initiated a festival in honor of Icarius and Erigone.

Dionysus' Gift to Midas of the Golden Touch

We have learned how the philosophical Silenus was captured and brought to King Midas.¹⁸ Midas at once recognized the satyr as a follower of Dionysus and returned him to Dionysus. The god was so delighted that he gave the king

the right to choose any gift he would like for himself. Midas foolishly asked that whatever he should touch might be turned into gold. At first, Midas was delighted with his new power, when he saw that he could transform everything into gleaming riches by the mere touch of his hand. But the blessing quickly became a curse, for he could no longer eat or drink; any morsel or drop that he brought to his lips became a solid mass of gold. Midas' greed turned to loathing; in some accounts, even his beloved daughter was transformed. He begged the god's forgiveness for his sin and release from his accursed power. Dionysus took pity and ordered the king to cleanse himself of the remaining traces of his guilt in the source of the river Pactolus, near Sardis. Midas obeyed, and the power of transforming things into gold passed from his person into the stream, whose sands forevermore were sands of gold.

Dionysus and the Pirates

In the *Homeric Hymn to Dionysus* (7), the god is abducted by pirates who mistake him for a mortal. The ensuing events aboard ship offer a splendid picture of Dionysus' power and majesty and remind us of fundamental elements in the nature of his character and worship: miracles, bestial transformation, violence to enemies, and pity and salvation for those who understand.¹⁹

I shall sing of how Dionysus, the son of renowned Semele, appeared as a man in the first bloom of youth on a projecting stretch of shore by the sea that bears no harvest. His hair, beautiful and dark, flowed thickly about his head, and he wore on his strong shoulders a purple cloak. Before long, foreign pirates, led on by evil fate, appeared swiftly over the sea, dark as wine, in a ship with fine benches of oars. As soon as they saw him, they nodded one to the other and, quickly jumping out, seized him at once and put him on board ship, delighted in their hearts. For they thought that he was the son of kings, who are cherished by Zeus, and wanted to bind him in harsh bonds. But the bonds fell far from his hands and feet and did not hold him as he sat with a smile in his dark eyes. (1–15)

When the helmsman saw this, he called aloud to his comrades: "Madmen, who is this mighty god whom you have seized and attempt to bind? Not even our strong ship can carry him, for this is either Zeus or Apollo of the silver bow or Poseidon, since he is not like mortal men but like the gods who have their homes on Olympus. But come, let us immediately set him free on the dark shore; do not lay hands on him for fear that he become angered in some way and rouse up violent winds and a great storm." (15–24)

So he spoke, but the commander of the ship rebuked him scornfully: "Madman, check the wind, and while you are at it seize the tackle and hoist



Dionysus and Maenads.

Black-figure amphora by the Amasis painter, ca. 530 B.C. Dionysus, clothed in a chiton (a kind of long shirt) and himation (cloak) and holding a kantharos (cup) of wine, salutes two maenads, each clothed in a patterned peplos, who link arms and dance. They hold tendrils of ivy, and the one on the right holds a small deer by its ears. (Bibliothèque nationale de France)



Audio



Dionysus. Kylix by Exekias, ca. 530 B.C.; diameter 4 ½ in. The scene depicts the story told in the *Homeric Hymn to Dionysus*. The god reclines on the pirates' ship, round whose mast a grape-laden vine entwines itself. The crew have leaped overboard and have been transformed into dolphins. (*Bildarchiv Preussischer Kulturbesitz/Art Resource, NY*)

the sail. I expect that he will come with us to Egypt or Cyprus or the northern Hyperboreans or farther. But at his destination he will eventually tell us about his friends and all his possessions and his brothers, since a divine power has put him in our hands." When he had spoken, the mast and sail were hoisted on the ship; the wind breathed into the midst of the sail and the men made the ropes tight all around. (25–34)

But soon deeds full of wonder appeared in their midst. First of all, a sweet and fragrant wine flowed through the black ship, and a divine ambrosial odor arose. Amazement took hold of all the sailors as they looked, and immediately a vine spread in all directions up along the very top of the sail, with many clusters hanging down; dark ivy, luxuriant with flowers, entwined about the mast, and lovely fruit burst forth, and all the oarpins bore garlands. When they saw this, they ordered the helmsman to bring the ship to land. But then the god became a terrifying lion in the upper part of the ship and roared loudly, and in the middle of the ship he created a shaggy-necked bear, thus manifesting his divinity. The bear stood up raging, while on the upper deck the lion glared and scowled. (34–48)

The sailors fled into the stern and stood in panic around the helmsman, who had shown his good sense. The lion sprang up suddenly and seized the commander of the ship, but the sailors when they saw this escaped an evil fate and leaped all together into the shining sea and became dolphins. (48–53)

The god took pity on the helmsman and saved him and made him happy and fortunate in every way, saying: "Be of good courage, you who have become dear to my heart. I am loud-crying Dionysus, whom my mother, Semele, daughter of Cadmus, bore after uniting in love with Zeus." (53–57)

Hail, son of Semele of the beautiful countenance; it is not at all possible to forget you and compose sweet song.

Pan

The god Pan has much in common with the satyrs and silenoi of Dionysus.²⁰ He is not completely human in form but part man and part goat—he has the horns, ears, and legs of a goat; he will join in Bacchic revels, and he is full of spirit, impulsive, and amorous. His parents are variously named: his mother is usually some nymph or other; his father is very often Hermes or Apollo. Like them, he is a god of shepherds and a musician.

Pan is credited with the invention of his own instrument, the **panpipe** (or in Greek, **syrix**); Ovid tells the story with brevity and charm (*Metamorphoses* 1. 689–712). Syrix was once a lovely nymph, devoted to Artemis, who rejected the advances of predatory satyrs and woodland spirits. Pan caught sight of her, and as he pursued her, she was transformed into a bed of marsh reeds. The wind

blowing through them produced a sad and beautiful sound, and Pan was inspired to cut two of the reeds, fasten them together with wax, and thus fashion a pipe on which he could play.

Pan's haunts are the hills and the mountains, particularly those of his homeland, **Arcadia**, and he came to be especially honored in Athens. According to Herodotus (6. 106), Pan was encountered by the runner Phidippides, who had been sent to Sparta by the Athenians to ask for help when they were about to fight the Persians at Marathon in 490. Phidippides claimed that Pan called him by name and asked why the Athenians ignored him although he was a deity friendly to them. The Athenians believed Phidippides and later built a shrine to Pan, honoring him with annual sacrifices and torch races.

Pan had other loves besides Syrinx.²¹ His passion for the nymph **Echo** also ended tragically. She fled from his advances, and Pan spread such madness and "panic" among a group of shepherds (a particular feat to which he was prone) that they tore her to pieces. All that remained was her voice.

The *Homeric Hymn to Pan* (19) presents a memorable account of his birth and his revels; in this case, his father is Hermes and his mother Dryope, the daughter of Dryops.

Tell me, O Muse, about the dear son of Hermes—Pan, goat-footed, two-horned, lover of musical clangor—who wanders through wooded meadows together with a chorus of nymphs dancing along the heights of sheer rock. They call upon Pan, the splendid shaggy-haired god of shepherds, who has for his domain every snowy ridge, and mountaintops and rocky summits. He roams this place and

The Dionysiaca of Nonnus

Nonnus, a poet from Panopolis in Egypt, composed in the fifth century A.D. a Greek epic poem in forty-eight books on the theme of Dionysus and his exploits. In the "Mythical Introduction" to the three-volume Loeb text, H. J. Rose begins with this arresting statement: "The mythology of the *Dionysiaca* is interesting as being the longest and most elaborate example we have of Greek myths in their final stage of degeneracy."²² Full of learned information, this work does have its moments (often more academic than poetic) that justify proclaiming Nonnus "the last great epic poet of antiquity."

Book 1 begins with Zeus carrying off Europa, and Book 48 concludes with Dionysus' final return to Olympus, where he places the crown of his beloved Ariadne. Nonnus, in his varied and crammed tapestry of countless events, gives us information that is to be found nowhere else—for example, the fight between Dionysus and Perseus and the myth of Beroë, a child of Aphrodite, invented to afford Berytus, the site of a great Roman school of law, its very own foundation-myth. One should single out as well Nonnus' wealth of knowledge of astronomy, astrology, and religious doctrine, especially that of the Orphics. The amorous exploits of Dionysus seem endless, and a whole group of his lovers are all metamorphosed into various plants. Most interesting and bizarre of all Nonnus' excesses is the lengthy account of Dionysus as world conqueror, whose military conquests are obviously inspired by the legendary career of Alexander the Great. This same author Nonnus is credited with a poetic paraphrase of the Gospel of John.



Pan Pursuing a Goatherd, by the Pan painter, Attic red-figure krater, ca. 460 B.C.; height 14 ½ in. Pan pursues a herdsman, possibly Daphnis, son of Hermes. Pan's intentions are clear, and his lust is wittily echoed by the herm (or, more likely, the figure of Priapus) in the rocky background. This is the reverse of the vase illustrated in Chapter 10 on page 227, which depicts the mortal Actaeon punished by the goddess Artemis. The impunity of divine lust contrasts with the tragic consequences of divine anger for human error. (Photograph © 2010. Museum of Fine Arts, Boston)

that through dense thickets; sometimes he is tempted by soft streams, and then again he passes among sheer rocks and climbs up to the highest peak that overlooks the flocks. Often he moves across gleaming high mountains; often, among the slopes, he presses on and, sharply on the outlook, kills animals. (1–14)

Then, in the evening only, returning from the chase, he plays a lovely tune on his pipe of reeds. Not even the nightingale, the bird that pours forth her sad lament in honeyed song amidst the petals of flower-laden spring, could surpass him in melody. With him then the clear-voiced mountain nymphs, moving on nimble feet, sing by a dark-watered spring; and Echo's wails reverberate around the mountaintop. The god Pan dances readily here and there among the chorus and then slips easily into their midst. He wears a spotted pelt of a lynx on his back, and his heart is delighted by his piercing tunes in a soft meadow where the crocus and fragrant hyacinth blooming at random mingle in the grass. (14–26)

They sing hymns about the blessed gods and high Olympus, and, above the rest, they single out Hermes, the bringer of luck. They sing how he is the swift messenger for all the gods and how he came into Arcadia, full of springs and mother of flocks, the place where his sacred precinct is located. There, even though he was a god, he tended the shaggy-fleeced sheep, in the service of a mortal. For a melting longing seized Hermes, and his passion to make love to the daughter of Dryops,²³ the nymph with the beautiful hair, intensified; and he brought to its fulfillment a fruitful marriage. (27–35)

Dryope bore to Hermes in their house a dear son, a marvel to behold right from his birth, a goat-footed, two-horned baby who loved music and laughter. But his mother was startled and fled, and she abandoned the child, for she was frightened when she saw his coarse features and full beard. Hermes, the luck-bringer, took him at once and clasped him in his arms; and the god felt extremely happy. Quickly, he covered the child in the thick skin of a mountain hare and went to the homes of the immortals and sat him down beside Zeus and the other gods and showed them the boy. All the immortals were delighted in their hearts, and especially Bacchic Dionysus; and they called him Pan because he delighted the hearts of them all.²⁴

So hail to you, lord. I pray to you with my song, and I shall remember both you and another song too. (35–49)

Echo and Narcissus

We know that because she rejected him, Pan caused Echo to be torn to pieces so that only her voice remained. A more famous story about Echo concerns her love for Narcissus. Ovid's version is as follows (*Metamorphoses* 3. 342–510):

The river-god Cephissus once embraced the nymph Liriope in his winding stream and, enveloping her in his waves, took her by force. When her time had come, the beautiful Liriope bore a child with whom even as a baby the nymphs might have fallen in love. And she called him Narcissus. She consulted the seer Tiresias, asking whether her son would live a long time to a ripe old age; his answer was: "Yes, if he will not have come to know himself." For a long time this response seemed to be an empty prophecy, but as things turned out, its truth was proven by the unusual nature of the boy's madness and death. (342–350)

The son of Cephissus had reached his sixteenth year and could be looked upon as both a boy and a young man. Many youths and many maidens desired him, but such a firm pride was coupled with his soft beauty that no one (either boy or girl) dared to touch him. He was seen once as he was driving the timid deer into his nets by the talkative nymph, who had learned neither to be silent when another is speaking nor to be the first to speak herself, namely, the mimic Echo. (351–358)

At that time, Echo was a person and not only a voice; but just as now, she was garrulous and was able to use her voice in her customary way of repeating from a flood of words only the very last. Juno brought this about because, when she might have been able to catch the nymphs lying on the mountain with her Jove, Echo knowingly detained the goddess by talking at length until the nymphs could run away. When Juno realized the truth, she exclaimed: "The power of that tongue of yours, by which I have been tricked, will be limited; and most brief will be the use of your voice." She made good her threats; Echo only gives back the words she has heard and repeats the final phrases of utterances. (359–369)

ECHO'S PASSION FOR NARCISSUS

And so she saw Narcissus wandering through the secluded countryside and burned with passion; she followed his footsteps furtively, and the closer she pursued him, the nearer was the fire that consumed her, just like the tops of torches, smeared with sulphur, that catch fire and blaze up when a flame is brought near. O how often she wanted to approach him with blandishments and tender appeals! Her very nature made this impossible, for she was not allowed to speak first. But she was prepared to wait for his utterances and to echo them with her own words—this she could do. (370–378)

By chance, the boy became separated from his faithful band of companions, and he cried out: "Is there anyone there?" Echo replied "There!" He was dumbfounded and glanced about in all directions; then he shouted at full voice: "Come!" She called back to him with the same word. He looked around but saw no one approaching; "Why do you run away from me?" he asked. She echoed his words just as he spoke them. He was persistent, beguiled by the reflection of the other's voice, and exclaimed: "Come here and let us get together!" Echo replied, "Let us get together," and never would she answer any other sound more willingly. She emerged from the woods, making good her very words and rushed to throw her arms about the neck of her beloved. But he fled and in his



Audio



Echo and Narcissus, by Nicolas Poussin (1594–1665); oil on canvas, ca. 1630, $29 \frac{1}{4} \times 39 \frac{1}{2}$ in. Narcissus lies along the edge of the pool with his flowers growing near his head, while Echo, waiflike, fades away in the background. The Cupid's burning torch is more fitting for a funeral than for a celebration of love. (Erich Lessing/Art Resource, NY)



Closer Look

flight exclaimed, “Take your hands off me; I would die before I let you possess me.” She replied with only the last words “Possess me.” (379–392)

Thus spurned, Echo hid herself in the woods where the trees hid her blushes; and from that time on she has lived in solitary caves. Nevertheless, her love clung fast and grew with the pain of rejection. Wakeful cares wasted away her wretched body, her skin became emaciated, and the bloom and vigor of her whole being slipped away on the air. Her voice and her bones were all that was left. Then only her voice remained; her bones, they say, were turned into stone. 50 From that time on, she has remained hidden in the woods; she is never seen on the mountains, but she is heard by everyone. The sound of her echo is all of her that still lives. (393–401)

Narcissus had played with her so, just as he had previously rejected other nymphs sprung from the waves or the mountains, and as well males who had approached him. Thereupon one of those scorned raised up his hands to the heavens and cried: “So may he himself fall in love, so may he not be able to possess his beloved!” The prayer was a just one, and Nemesis heard it. (402–406)

NARCISSUS' PASSION FOR HIS OWN REFLECTION

There was a spring, its clear waters glistening like silver, untouched by shepherds, mountain goats, and other animals, and undisturbed by birds, wild 60 beasts, and falling tree branches. Grass grew round about, nourished by the water nearby, and the woods protected the spot from the heat of the sun. Here

the boy lay down, tired out by the heat and his quest for game and attracted by the pool and the beauty of the place. While he was trying to quench his thirst, it kept coming back again and again, and as he continued to drink, he was captivated by the reflection of the beauty that he saw. (407–416)

He fell in love with a hope insubstantial, believing what was only an image to be real and corporeal. He gazed in wonder at himself, clinging transfixed and emotionless to what he saw, just like a statue formed from Parian marble. From his position on the ground he looked at his eyes, twin stars, and his hair, worthy of both Bacchus and Apollo, and his smooth cheeks, his ivory neck, and the beauty of his face, a flush of red amid snowy whiteness. He marveled at all the things that others had marveled at in him. Unwise and unheeding, he desired his very self, one and the same person approving and being approved, seeking and being sought, inflaming and being inflamed. How many times he bestowed vain kisses on the deceptive pool! How many times he plunged his arms into the midst of the waters to grasp the neck that he saw! But he could not catch hold of himself in their embrace. He did not understand what he was looking at, but was inflamed by what he saw, and the same illusion that deceived his eyes aroused his passion. (417–431)

Poor deluded boy, why do you grasp at your fleeting reflection to no avail? What you seek is not real; just turn away and you will lose what you love. What you perceive is but the reflection of your own image; it has no substance of its own. With you it comes and stays, and with you it will go, if you can bear to go. No concern for food or rest could drag him away from his post, but stretched out on the shady grass he looks at this deceptive beauty with insatiable gaze and destroys himself through his own eyes. He raised himself up a little and stretching out his arms to the surrounding woods exclaimed: (432–441)

“Has there ever been anyone smitten by more cruel a love? Tell me, O trees, for you know since you have provided opportune haunts for countless lovers. In the length of your years, in the many ages you have lived, can you remember anyone who has wasted away like me? I behold my beloved, but what I see and love I cannot have; such is the frustration of my unrequited passion. And I am all the more wretched because it is not a vast sea or lengthy road or impregnable fortress that separates us. Only a little water keeps us from each other. My beloved desires to be held, for each time that I bend down to kiss the limpid waters, he in return strains upward with his eager lips. You would think that he could be touched; it is such a little thing that prevents the consummation of our love. Whoever you are, come out to me here. Why, incomparable boy, do you deceive me? When I pursue you, where do you go? Certainly you do not flee from my youthful beauty, for nymphs loved me too. You promise me some kind of hope by your sympathetic looks of friendship. When I stretch forth my arms to you, you do the same in return. When I laugh, you laugh back, and I have often noted your tears in response to my weeping. And as well you return my every gesture and nod; and, as far as I can surmise from movements of your lovely mouth, you answer me with words that never reach my ears. I am you! I realize it; my reflection does not deceive me; I burn with love for myself, I am the one who fans the flame and bears the torture. What am I to do? Should I be the one to be asked or to ask? What then shall I ask for? What I desire is with me; all that I have makes me poor. O how I wish that I could escape from my body! A strange prayer for one in love, to wish away what he loves! And now grief consumes my strength; the time remaining for me is short, and my life will be

snuffed out in its prime. Death does not weigh heavily upon me, for death will bring an end to my misery. I only wish that he whom I cherish could live a longer time. As it is, we two who are one in life shall die together!" (442–473)

THE METAMORPHOSIS OF NARCISSUS

He finished speaking and, sick with longing, turned back again to his own reflection. His tears disturbed the waters and caused the image in the pool to grow less distinct. When he saw it disappearing, he screamed: "Where are you going? Stay here, do not desert me, your lover. I cannot touch you—let me look at you, give me this nourishment at least in my misery and madness." As he grieved, he tore his garment in its upper part and beat his bare chest with his marble-white hands. And his chest when struck took on a rosy tinge, as apples usually have their whiteness streaked with red, or grapes in various clusters when not yet ripe are stained with purple. As soon as he beheld himself thus in the water that was once again calm, he could endure it no further; but, as yellow wax is wont to melt under the touch of fire and the gentle frost under the warmth of the sun, so he was weakened and destroyed by love, gradually being consumed in its hidden flame. His beautiful complexion, white touched with red, no longer remained nor his youthful strength, nor all that he had formerly looked upon with such pleasure. Not even his body, which Echo had once loved, was left. (474–493) 120

When Echo saw what he had become, she felt sorry, even though she had been angry and resentful. Each time that the poor boy exclaimed "Alas," she repeated in return an echoing "Alas." And as he struck his shoulders with his hands, she gave back too the same sounds of his grief. This was his last cry as he gazed into the familiar waters: "Alas for the boy I cherished in vain!" The place repeated these very same words. And when he said "Farewell," Echo repeated "Farewell" too. He relaxed his weary head on the green grass; night closed those eyes that had so admired the beauty of their owner. Then too, after he had been received in the home of the dead below, he gazed at himself in the waters of the Styx. His sister Naiads wept and cut off their hair and offered it to their brother; the Dryads wept, and Echo sounded their laments. Now the pyre and streaming torches and the bier were being prepared, but the corpse was nowhere to be seen. They found instead a yellow flower with a circle of white petals in its center. (494–510) 140

Narcissism

This tragic story of self-love and self-destruction has cast a particularly potent spell on subsequent literature and thought, not least of all because of Ovid's perceptive and moving tale. The fact that it was a male lover's prayer for just retribution that was answered defines the homoerotic nature of Narcissus' self-love and self-destruction.²⁵ We do believe that Ovid intends us to understand that a male lover (*aliquis*) was rejected because then Narcissus' affliction becomes so ironic and so just: "Let the punishment fit the crime." The ominous words of Tiresias predict the tragedy in a fascinating variation of the most Greek of themes, "Know thyself," preached by Apollo and learned by Oedipus and Socrates. "When his mother inquired if Narcissus would live to a ripe old age, the seer Tiresias answered, "Yes, if he will not have come to know himself." We should not be surprised that Ovid is so profound.

“Narcissism” and “narcissistic” have been technical psychological terms and part of our everyday vocabulary since 1914, the year of Freud’s paper “On Narcissism: An Introduction.”²⁶

Select Bibliography

- Bloom, Harold.** *Euripides*. New York: Chelsea House, 2003.
- Carpenter, Thomas.** *Dionysian Imagery in Fifth Century Athens*. New York: Oxford University Press, 1997.
- , and **C. A. Faraone, eds.** *Masks of Dionysus*. Ithaca, NY: Cornell University Press, 1993. Essays about the influence of Dionysus and tragedy.
- Dodds, E. R.** *The Greeks and the Irrational*. Berkeley: University of California Press, 1951.
- Kerényi, Carl.** *Dionysos: Archetypal Image of Indestructible Life*. Translated by Ralph Manheim. Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1996 [1976].
- Merivale, Patricia.** *Pan the Goat-God, His Myth in Modern Times*. New York: Cambridge University Press, 1969.
- Otto, Walter F.** *Dionysus: Myth and Cult*. Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 1965.
- Seaford, Richard.** *Dionysos*. Gods and Heroes of the Ancient World Series. New York: Routledge, 2006.

Primary Sources

Sources in the Chapter

Euripides	<i>Bacchae</i>
Homeric Hymn 1	<i>To Dionysus</i>
Homeric Hymn 7	<i>To Dionysus</i>
Homeric Hymn 19	<i>To Pan</i>
Homeric Hymn 26	<i>To Dionysus</i>
Ovid	<i>Metamorphoses</i> 3.342–510

Additional Sources

Apollodorus	<i>Library</i> 3.4.3–3.5.1
Bacchylides	<i>Ode</i> 11.39–112 (How Hera drove the daughters of Proetus mad)
Euripides	<i>Cyclops</i> (Silenus and his satyr sons must serve the Cyclops Polyphemus)
Nonnus	<i>Dionysiaca</i>

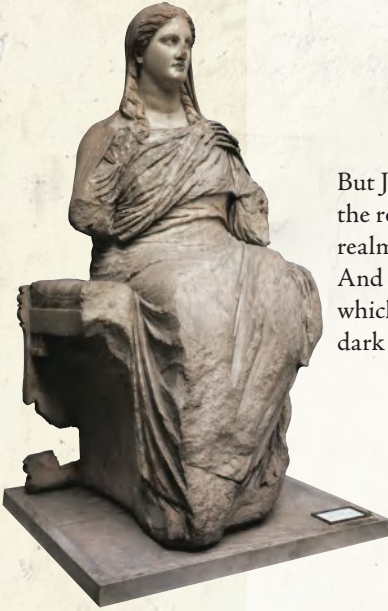
Notes

1. Bacchus, the name for the god preferred by the Romans, is often used by the Greeks as well.
2. The word *dithyrambos*, an epithet of Dionysus and the name of a type of choral poetry that included hymns sung in the god’s honor, was in ancient times believed to refer etymologically to his double birth.
3. The career of Ino is extremely confusing because of the multiple versions of her story. She was the second wife of Athamas (whom we shall meet again in the Argonautic saga), and they had two sons, Learchus and Melicertes. Angry with Ino because of

her care for Dionysus, Hera drove both Ino and her husband mad. Athamas killed his son Learchus and pursued Ino, who escaped with Melicertes in her arms. She leaped from a cliff into the sea and was transformed into the sea-goddess Leucothea; Melicertes also became deified under the new name of Palaemon.

4. Note the Dionysiac aspects of Orpheus' missionary zeal in Thrace, which establish the influence of the god there.
5. The Curetes, as we have seen, are the attendants of Rhea, who hid the cries of the infant Zeus from his father Cronus (see box, p. 75). In this passage, Euripides associates them with the Corybantes, the ministers of Cybele.
6. We have translated only the beginning and end of Tiresias' lengthy and learned sermon on the great power of Dionysus.
7. Harry Partch, *Bitter Music, Collected Journals, Essays, Introductions, and Librettos*, ed. Thomas McGeary (Urbana: University of Illinois Press, 1991), pp. 244–246. Reprinted from his *Genesis of Music*. 2d ed. (New York: Da Capo Press, 1974 [1949]).
8. Amphiaraüs, a seer and one of the Seven against Thebes, was a descendant of Melampus. The wife of Proetus, Stheneboea, is prominent in the myth of Bellerophon (see pp. 550–552).
9. The initial nine lines, quoted by Diodorus Siculus (3. 66. 3), are probably not a separate hymn but should in some way be joined to the fragmentary last section of this first hymn, which is found in manuscript.
10. The epithet *eiraphiotes* is of uncertain derivation. It may mean “insewn,” but it may instead refer to Dionysus' connection with the ivy plant or the goat or the bull.
11. Dracanum is a cape on the island of Cos; Icarus and Naxos are islands, and the Alpheus is a river in Elis.
12. There must be a lacuna after these lines from Diodorus and before the next section from the manuscript text.
13. The reference to three things is unclear; it may refer to the ritual of dismemberment.
14. E. R. Dodds' helpful edition of the Greek text of the *Bacchae*, 2d ed. (New York: Oxford University Press, 1960), includes an enlightening introduction. He notes that Dionysiac religion shares a belief, found universally, that musical rhythms and ritual dances lead to the most satisfying and highest religious experiences. See also Walter F. Otto, *Dionysus: Myth and Cult* (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 1965 [1933]); M. Detienne, *Dionysos at Large* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1989 [1986]); Carl Kerényi, *Dionysos: Archetypal Image of Indestructible Life*. Translated from the German by Ralph Mannheim. Bollingen Series LXV.2 (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1976); and Thomas H. Carpenter and Christopher A. Faraone, eds., *Masks of Dionysus*. Myth and Poetics Series (Ithaca, NY: Cornell University Press, 1993), a collection of essays about various aspects of Dionysus and his worship.
15. Vergil wrote a famous adaptation of this legend in his sixth *Eclogue*, in which the utterance of the silenus is cosmogonical and mythological.
16. Friedrich Nietzsche has provided the most imaginative and influential modern analysis of the Dionysiac experience, particularly in enunciating its antithetical relationship to the Apollonian. See M. S. Silk and J. P. Stern, *Nietzsche on Tragedy* (New York: Cambridge University Press, 1981), a study of Nietzsche's first book, *The Birth of Tragedy*.
17. Variations in the story are obviously etiological attempts to account for elements of Bacchic ritual. Later ceremonies enacted the passion, death, and resurrection of the god in all their details.
18. Ovid's version of Midas' story (*Metamorphoses* 11. 85–145) is well known. This is the same Midas whose ears were turned into those of an ass as a result of his preference for the music of Pan over that of Apollo (see pp. 265–266).
19. The same story is told by Ovid (*Metamorphoses* 3. 597–691), who provides an interesting comparison in artistic method and purpose.
20. See Philippe Borgeaud, *The Cult of Pan in Ancient Greece* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1988) for a study of changing representations of Pan. See also Patricia

- Merivale, *Pan the Goat-God: His Myth in Modern Times* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1969).
21. Another nymph he pursued was turned into a tree that bore her name, Pitys (the Greek word for “pine”).
 22. Nonnos, *Dionysiaca*. Translated by W. H. D. Rouse (New York: Harvard University Press, 1934), vol. 1, p. x.
 23. This is Dryope; Ovid (*Metamorphoses* 9. 325 ff.) has a different version.
 24. The Greek word *pan* means “all.”
 25. See Louise Vinge, *The Narcissus Theme in Western European Literature Up to the Early 19th Century* (Lund, Sweden: Gleerups, 1967); also Gerasimos Santas, *Plato and Freud: Two Theories of Love* (Oxford: Blackwell, 1988). Freud believed (and of course many disagree) that an individual’s sexual development as an infant may determine his or her choices as an adult concerning the object and nature of love. Thus the theory of narcissism had a great impact on his conviction that, for some, relationships in love may stem not from their primal attachment to their mothers but from infantile self-love.
 26. See *The Standard Edition of the Complete Psychological Works of Sigmund Freud*, edited by James Strachey, vol. 14 (London: Hogarth Press, 1957), pp. 69–129. Of great interest is a biography of the psychoanalyst Heinz Kohut by Charles B. Strozier, *Heinz Kohut: The Making of a Psychoanalyst* (New York: Farrar, Straus & Giroux, 2001). Kohut became famous through his profound exploration of narcissism in papers such as “Forms and Transformations of Narcissism” (1966) and “The Analysis of the Self” (1971).



Demeter and the Eleusinian Mysteries

But Jupiter mediated between his brother and his sorrowful sister and divided the rolling year equally. Now the goddess, her divinity shared between two realms, lives with her mother for as many months as she lives with her husband. And suddenly the cast of her mind and face changed. For now her countenance, which could seem mournful even to Dis, is radiant as the sun, emerging from the dark clouds that had concealed it.

—OVID, *Metamorphoses* 5.564–571

The Myth of Demeter and Persephone

There are two *Homeric Hymns to Demeter*. Number 13 is a very short prelude.



Audio

I begin to sing about the holy goddess Demeter of the beautiful hair, about her and her very lovely daughter Persephone. Hail, goddess; preserve this city and lead my song.

The lengthy and powerful *Homeric Hymn to Demeter* (2), by contrast, is of the utmost importance; it begins with Hades' abduction of Persephone at the will of Zeus:

I begin to sing about the holy goddess, Demeter of the beautiful hair, about her and her daughter, Persephone of the lovely ankles, whom Hades snatched away; loud-thundering Zeus, who sees all, gave her to him. (1–3)

Alone, away from Demeter of the golden scepter and goodly crops, Persephone was playing with the deep-bosomed daughters of Oceanus and picking flowers along a soft meadow: beautiful roses, crocuses, violets, irises, and hyacinths; and Earth in accordance with the